

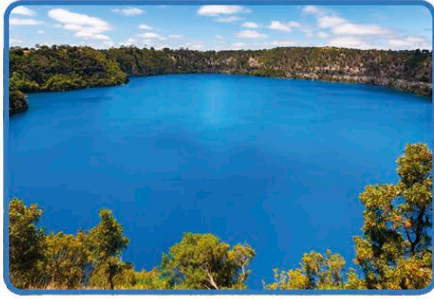
Habitats and biomes

Around Earth, plants, animals, and other organisms live in habitats that are as different as the driest, most windswept deserts and the deepest, darkest oceans.

Conditions vary from one part of the world to another, and they have a big effect on the kinds of living things that can survive together in any place. The freezing cold poles experience a winter of unbroken darkness for half the year, while the equator basks in tropical temperatures year-round. And the world of the oceans reaches from the sunlit surfaces down into the dark abyss.

Freshwater

Rainfall collecting in rivers and lakes creates freshwater habitats. Aquatic plants grow in their shallows and animals swim in the open water or crawl along their muddy or stony bottoms. Where rivers meet the sea, water is affected by the oceans' saltiness.



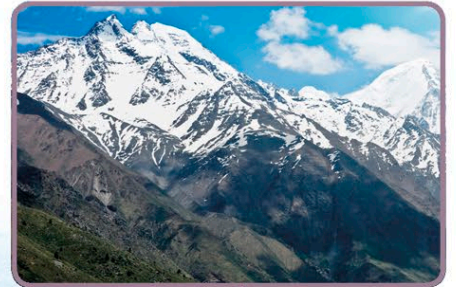
Mediterranean woodland

A Mediterranean-type climate has hot, dry summers and wet, mild winters. It is most common where lands in the temperate zone are influenced by mild ocean air. Its forests are dominated by trees—such as eucalyptus—that are sclerophyll, meaning they have leathery, heat-resistant leaves.



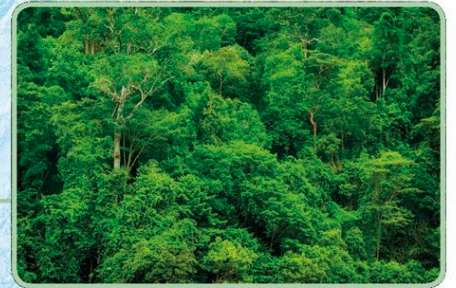
Montane grassland and shrubland

Temperatures drop with increasing altitude, so the habitat changes in mountain regions. Forests give way to grassland on exposed slopes, which are then replaced with sparser vegetation—called montane tundra—higher up.



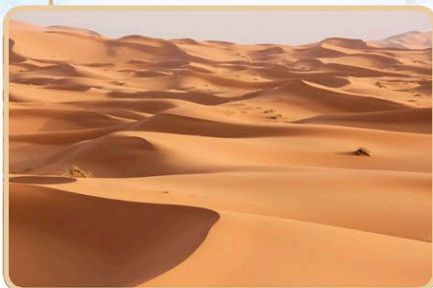
Tropical rainforest

Where temperature, rainfall, and humidity remain high all year round, Earth is covered with tropical rainforest. These are the best conditions for many plants and animals to grow, and they have evolved into more different species than in any other land biome.



Desert

In some parts of the world—in temperate or tropical regions—the land receives so little rainfall that conditions are too dry for most grasses and trees. In arid places with hot days and cold nights, succulent plants survive by storing water in roots, stems, or leaves.



Tropical grassland

Grasslands in the tropics support some of the largest, most diverse gatherings of big grazing animals anywhere on Earth. Unlike most plants, grasses grow from the base of their leaves and thrive even when vast numbers of grazers eat the top of their foliage.

